

Session 11: The Anti-Remnant

Key Takeaways

- Throughout the biblical story, God saves a righteous remnant to carry forward his plan to bless the world.
- Ezekiel 14 echoes vocabulary from the flood narrative of Genesis 6-8.
- Ezekiel 14 turns the righteous remnant theme on its head. God's covenant partners will pass through the death of exile. And even if there were a righteous representative, they would not deliver the city from destruction.

Translation and Literary Design of Ezekiel 14:1-11

Chapter 14 begins with judgment against idolatry and the deception of the prophets (see also [1 Kgs. 22](#)).

¹ And men from the elders of Israel came
and they sat before me,
² and the word of Yahweh came to me saying,
³ "Son of a human,
these men have set up their idols in their hearts
and they have set before themselves the stumbling block of their iniquity.
Should I be inquired of by them?
⁴ Therefore speak to them
and say to them,
'Thus says the Lord Yahweh:
Anyone from the house of Israel who sets up his idols in his heart,
and who sets the stumbling block of his iniquity before himself,
and then comes to the prophet,
I Yahweh myself will answer him because of it,
in view of his many idols,
⁵ in order to catch hold of the heart of the house of Israel,
who has stumbled away from me due to all of their idols.

⁶ Therefore, say to the house of Israel, 'Thus says **[the Lord]** Yahweh, 'Repent, and turn back from your idols,
and turn your faces from all your abominations.

⁷ For any one of the house of Israel or from the sojourner who sojourns in Israel, who separates himself from me and sets up his idols in his heart and set his stumbling block of his iniquity before himself, and then goes to the prophet to inquire of me through him, I Yahweh will be brought to answer him myself.

⁸ And I will make him a sign and a parable, and I will cut him off from the midst of my people, and you will know that I am Yahweh.

⁹ And the prophet, if he is deceived and speaks a word, I Yahweh have deceived that prophet, and I will stretch out my hand against him and I will destroy him from the midst of my people Israel.

¹⁰ And they shall bear their own guilt: like the guilt of the one who inquires, so shall be the guilt of the prophet.

¹¹ So that they can no longer lead astray the house of Israel from me, and they will no longer defile themselves with all their transgressions; and they will be to me a people, and I will be their God.

Ezekiel 14:1-11. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Key Interpretive Issues in Ezekiel 14:1-11

“[14:4—I Yahweh will impart him an answer ‘by myself.’] Instead of the ordinary form, the reflexive (Niph.) stem of the vb. is used here and v. 7 to bring out the special character of the answer: it will come direct from Jahveh to the enquirer, without any intermediary, and, as the context implies, it will take shape in deeds, not words. An enquirer who is divided in his allegiance can have no fellowship with Jahveh, and therefore no knowledge of His will conveyed by an inspired prophet.”

Cooke, G. A. (1970). [*A Critical and Exegetical Commentary on The Book of Ezekiel*](#). T. & T. Clark Limited, Ltd. 151.

Professional court prophets were taken in the first wave of the exile with Jehoiachin in 597 (see [Jer. 29:1, 15](#)). They clearly supported Jerusalem and its king, and they contradicted Ezekiel and Jeremiah’s message that Yahweh appointed the destruction by Babylon ([Jer. 27](#)). Here, Ezekiel challenges their claim to speak on behalf of Yahweh.

Translation and Literary Design of Ezekiel 14:12-23

¹² And the word of Yahweh came to me:

¹³ “Son of a human,
when a land sins against me by acting faithlessly,
and I stretch out my hand against it,
and I break its staff of bread,
and I send famine upon it,

and I cut off from it human and beast,

¹⁴ **even if these three men were in it,**

Noah, Daniel, and Job,

they would deliver, by their own righteousness, only their own lives,

declares Yahweh Elohim.

¹⁵ **If I cause wild beasts to pass through the land,**

and they make it childless,

and it becomes desolate,

so that no one may pass through because of the beasts,

¹⁶ **even if these three men were in it,**

as I live, declares Yahweh Elohim,

they would deliver neither sons nor daughters.

They alone would be delivered,

and the land would be desolate.

¹⁷ **Or if I bring a sword upon that land,**

and I say, "Let a sword pass through the land,"

and I cut off from it human and beast,

¹⁸ **if these three men were in it,**

as I live, declares Yahweh Elohim,

they would deliver neither sons nor daughters,

but they alone would be delivered.

¹⁹ **Or if I send a plague into that land,**

and pour out my hot anger upon it with blood,

to cut off from it man and beast,

²⁰ **even if Noah, Daniel, and Job were in it,**

as I live, declares Yahweh Elohim,

they would deliver neither son nor daughter.

They would deliver but their own lives by their righteousness.

²¹ For thus says Yahweh Elohim:

How much more when I send upon Jerusalem my four disastrous acts of judgment,

sword, famine, wild beasts, and plague,

to cut off from it human and beast!

²² But look, some survivors will be left as a remnant in it,

sons and daughters who will be brought out;

look, when they come out to you,

and you see their ways and their deeds,

then **you will be comforted** for the disaster that I have brought upon Jerusalem,

for all that I have brought upon it.

²³ **They will bring** **comfort** to you,
when you see their ways and their deeds,
and you shall know that I have not done without cause
all that I have done in it,
declares Yahweh Elohim.”

Ezekiel 14:12-23. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Jerusalem is Doomed: the Anti-Remnant

The exiles who have been separated from family and friends back in Jerusalem (see [14:22](#)) wonder if Yahweh might spare the entire city on account of a few righteous people (like he entertained with Abraham about Lot's family in Sodom, [Gen. 18](#)).

Ezekiel creates a hypothetical "righteous non-Israelite hall of fame" by naming Noah (see [Gen. 6:9](#)), Job ([Job 1:1, 8](#)), and Daniel (or perhaps, Dan'el, a famous Syrian king, father of Aqhat, renown for his wisdom and justice who is mentioned again in [Ezek. 28:3](#)).

By creating this hypothetical "land" that would not be saved by this righteous trio, Jerusalem is "worse than the nations" (see [Ezek. 5:6](#)), for Yahweh considered "salvation by association" for at least Sodom ([Gen. 18](#)).

The Remnant Revised

Any survivors that do make it to Babylon will prove they were not saved by their own virtuous character. Rather, they will show that Yahweh's judgment on Jerusalem was fully legitimate (v.23 the ironic "consolation" of [Isa. 40:1](#) here takes on a different meaning).

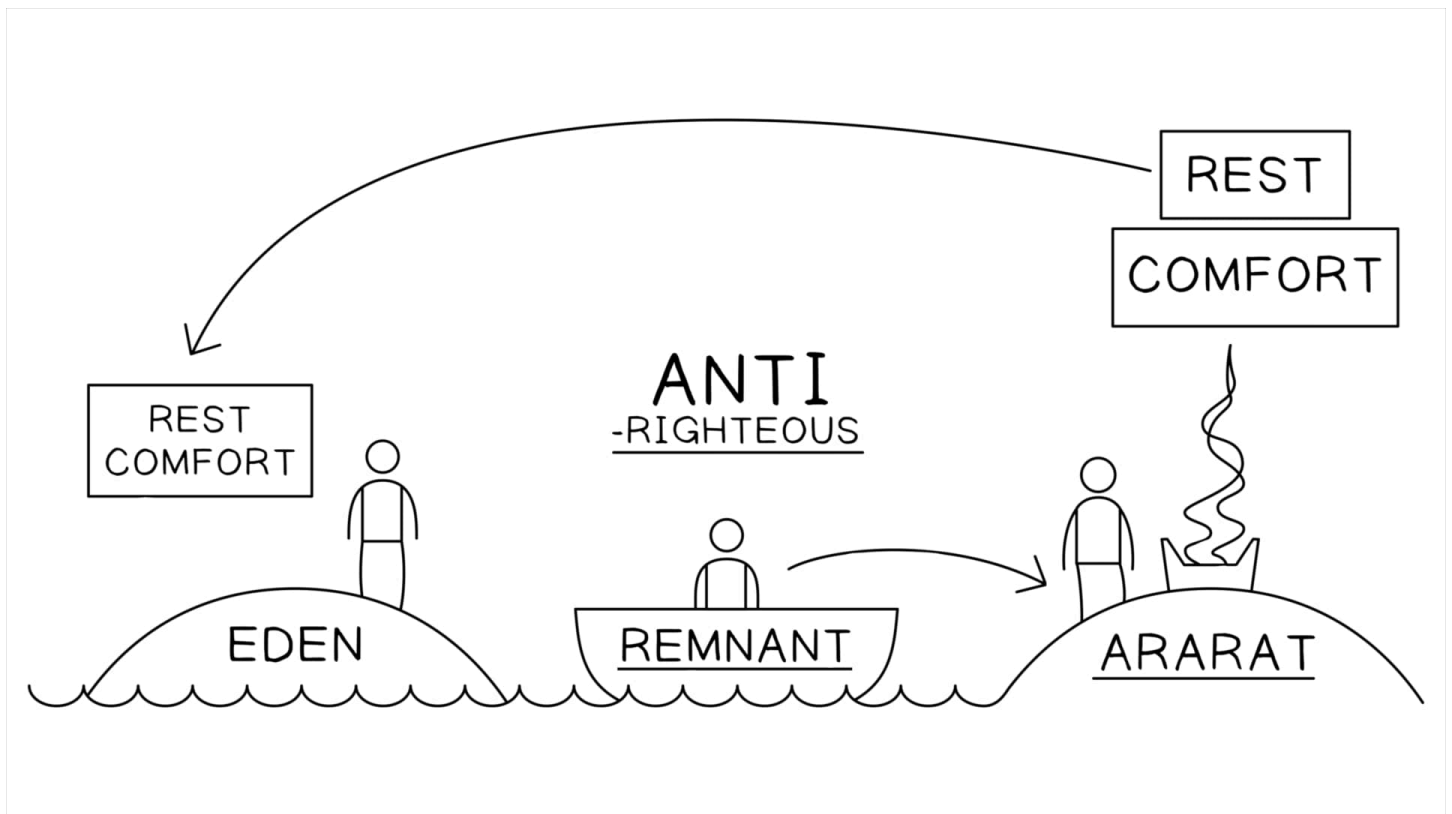
Literary Design

- 14:12: Introduction
- 14:13-20: Four Scenarios From [Leviticus 26](#): famine (14:13-14), wild animals (14:15-16), sword (14:17-18), and plague (14:19-20)
- 14:21-23: The Guilty Remnant

Compositional Location

The opening line uses a new phrase (14:13 "treacherously commit treachery" [לְמַעַל מַעַל](#), adopted from [Lev. 26:40](#)) to describe Israel's covenant rebellion. This phrase is next repeated at the conclusion of the following parable oracle ([15:1-8](#)) and acts as a frame around these two units. The point: Israel's treachery has both sealed Jerusalem's fate (14:12-23) and rendered them useless for the divine purpose (15:1-8).

The Anti-Remnant



The Anti-Remnant. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Reflection Question

How does Ezekiel use the theme of the remnant to deliver God's message in this chapter?